DETERMINANTS OF FOREIGN POLICY

Various factors influence the making of foreign policy of a particular country. Even the basic determinants vary in importance according to circumstances. It is impossible to lay down any general rule regarding the relative importance of each of these factors or a scale of priorities which the decision-makers must permanently adhere to in making their policy decisions. Nevertheless, certain basic determinants can be identified which most of the states take into account while making their policy.

Among the **domestic determinants or internal determinants** the most significant ones are discussed now.

1. ***Geography:*** Perhaps this is the most stable determinant of foreign policy. This includes the size of the territory, topography, location relative to sea and landmasses relative to other nations and control of strategic places.

Size means the total landmass that a state controls or exercises its sovereign authority on. But a large area contributes only to a state's power if it is capable of providing it with the capacity of containing a large population and a large and varied supply of natural resources.

More important than size is the geo-strategic **location** of the state in the sense that the position of a state in relationship to other land bodies and to other states profoundly affects the culture, economy and both its military and economic powers. The insularity of Great Britain and the isolated position of the United States have greatly affected the foreign policy decisions of those states.

Climate is another geographical feature that plays a crucial role in determining a state's foreign policy. Extremes of climate make functioning and development of a modern industrial society difficult. Climate does affect national power of states and, therefore, its foreign policy through its direct impact on agriculture, which is required to support its population.

Topography is another important geographical feature affecting foreign policy decisions. It not only determines the density of population which a region can support, but also the climate of the land. Wind, rainfall, temperature and, consequently, soil conditions